

might be 1.56 more times likely to die in the next year compared to the rest of his age group. Compare this scenario to a male in the same age group who has completed a college education: His probability of dying is only a fraction of the rate that applies to the rest of the group.

TABLE 2.1 Education Versus Mortality: Males

Education	Age 35–49	Age 50–64	Age 65–75
< High School	1.56 x	1.36 x	1.23 x
High School	1.11 x	1.05 x	0.98 x
Some College	0.97 x	0.89 x	0.90 x
College	0.55 x	0.64 x	0.62 x

Source: J.P. Cristia, August 2007, *Congressional Budget Office*, Working Paper #11, “The Empirical Relationship Between Lifetime Earnings and Mortality.”

TABLE 2.2 Education Versus Mortality: Females

Education	Age 35–49	Age 50–64	Age 65–75
< High School	1.61 x	1.48 x	1.26 x
High School	1.12 x	0.89 x	0.91 x
Some College	0.78 x	0.82 x	0.81 x
College	0.58 x	0.64 x	0.68 x

Source: J.P. Cristia, August 2007, *Congressional Budget Office*, Working Paper 11, “The Empirical Relationship Between Lifetime Earnings and Mortality.”

With all these studies, it is important not to confuse a statistical correlation between two factors, and actual causality. That is, numerous other factors might impact the education-longevity relationship. As an extreme case, a high school dropout who develops a sudden heart condition won’t miraculously get better if she completes her GED or re-enrolls in high school. All we can say for certain is that mortality rates are lower among groups of people within the general population who have completed high school and are even lower for the college educated, compared to people who have dropped out of high school. And so, from a practical perspective, if you are a member of the groups identified as having more favorable mortality experience, you should plan for a much longer retirement compared to the